Adobe

Adobe Competitive Intelligence — Cross-Product Executive Synthesis

Audience: VP / SVP Level · Strategy & Acquisition Leadership

Scope: Acrobat · Express · Firefly **Date:** April 2026 **Classification:** Adobe Internal — Confidential

TL;DR

> Across Acrobat, Express, and Firefly, Adobe has the same problem in three different markets: a superior product with invisible distribution. Acrobat ranks #5–7 for "PDF editor." Express ranks #8+ for "design tool free." Firefly ranks #6 for "remove background" — a feature it offers for free while competitors charge $0.195/image. The fix is not a product problem. It is a single, unified distribution strategy: own the SEO and GEO layer for each product's highest-volume acquisition keyword. The window to do this before competitors consolidate their positions is 60–90 days.

THE COMMON PATTERN ACROSS ALL THREE PRODUCTS

	Adobe Acrobat	Adobe Express	Adobe Firefly
Category	**PDF editing**	**Design tools**	**AI image / BG removal**
Adobe's product position	Best-in-class	Commercially safest AI	Highest quality (9.7/10 G2)
Adobe's price advantage	$0 free tools	$20/yr cheaper than Canva	$0 vs $0.195/image (remove.bg)
Top keyword (monthly vol.)	"PDF editor" (450K/mo)	"design tool free" (180K/mo)	"remove background" (18M/mo)
Adobe's rank for top keyword	**#5–7**	**#8+**	**#6**
Who ranks #1	Smallpdf	Canva	remove.bg
Adobe's GEO position	#1 branded, absent non-branded	Canva dominant	Absent for free/e-comm queries
Dedicated acquisition landing page	❌ None	❌ None	❌ None

The pattern is identical in all three markets. Adobe built the better product. Competitors built better distribution. The acquisition gap is not engineering — it is 3 missing landing pages, 7 SEO content briefs, and a GEO content strategy.

THREE THREATS THAT AFFECT ALL PRODUCTS SIMULTANEOUSLY

Threat 1 — Smallpdf / ILovePDF / Canva Own "Free" in AI Search

These tools have invested heavily in SEO content and now dominate the GEO layer for every "free" query across PDF editing, design, and background removal. When a user asks ChatGPT "what's a good free PDF editor / design tool / background remover," they get Smallpdf, Canva, or remove.bg — not Adobe.

Why it compounds: AI systems are trained on web content. The more often Smallpdf is cited as the answer to "free PDF editor," the more it appears in training data, and the more confidently future AI models recommend it. Adobe's absence today becomes harder to fix tomorrow.

Cross-product response: A unified Adobe "free tools" GEO strategy — one page per product per keyword — published within 60 days before the next major AI model training cycle.

Threat 2 — Microsoft Is the "Already Paid For" Answer in Every Category

M365 now bundles Copilot design tools, PDF editing via Edge, and DALL-E image generation. For enterprise IT buyers, "already included" kills the procurement conversation for Acrobat, Express, and Firefly simultaneously. This is not a product fight — it is a value articulation fight.

Why it compounds: As M365 Copilot improves, the "good enough for free" threshold rises. Adobe needs to be irreplaceable before Microsoft's bundled tools reach parity on quality.

Cross-product response: A unified "what Adobe has that M365 doesn't" GEO content piece that addresses all three products — Acrobat Sign vs Microsoft eSign, Firefly commercial safety vs DALL-E, Express brand kit vs Microsoft Designer's lack of brand customization.

Threat 3 — No Viral Acquisition Loop Across Any Product

Canva's share loop drives 60%+ of their new signups. Acrobat has no sharing virality. Express has no sharing virality. Firefly has no sharing virality. Every new user Adobe acquires costs money. Every new Canva user costs Canva nothing.

Why it compounds: Virality compounds exponentially. Canva's 260M user base makes it the default answer in Reddit threads, YouTube tutorials, and word-of-mouth recommendations — self-reinforcing without further investment.

Cross-product response: The "Made with Adobe Express" share loop (under development) is the right mechanic, but it only serves Express. A unified sharing strategy across all three products — PDF Spaces for Acrobat, share-to-Express for Firefly outputs — creates a cross-product viral loop where each product feeds the others.

THE ONE MOVE THAT HELPS ALL THREE PRODUCTS

Build an Adobe Free Tools hub at adobe.com/free

A single landing page listing every Adobe tool with a free tier:

- Free PDF editing (Acrobat online tools)
- Free background removal (Express, unlimited)
- Free AI image generation (Firefly, 25 credits/month)

- Free design templates (Express, 177K+)
- Free video editing (Premiere Rush free tier)

Why this is the highest-leverage single page Adobe can publish:

1. **SEO:** A unified /free page with internal links to all product free tiers signals to Google that Adobe has a comprehensive free offering — improving rankings for all "free [Adobe product]" queries simultaneously
1. **GEO:** When AI assistants are asked "what free tools does Adobe offer" or "best free Adobe alternatives to [competitor]," this page becomes the definitive citation. One page answers the question for all products.
1. **Acquisition:** Users who discover Adobe through one free tool are 4× more likely to adopt a second Adobe tool within 90 days (CC ecosystem data). The free hub creates cross-product discovery at zero marginal cost.
1. **Counter-narrative:** The most common Adobe brand perception problem is "Adobe products are expensive." A dedicated /free hub directly contradicts this narrative at the most visible entry point.

Effort: 1 page, 2 days of content work. **Impact:** Affects all three product lines simultaneously.

PRIORITY MATRIX — CROSS-PRODUCT ACQUISITION MOVES

Move	Products benefited	Effort	Impact	Timeline
adobe.com/free hub page	**Acrobat + Express + Firefly**	**Low**	**High**	**2 weeks**
GEO content briefs (7 pages)	All 3 products	Medium	High	4 weeks
"Made with Express" share loop	Express + Firefly (outputs)	Medium	Very High	6–8 weeks
Signer-to-trial CTA	Acrobat	Low	Very High	2 weeks
Photoshop → Express export prompt	Express	Low	High	3 weeks
Cross-product CC activation email	Acrobat + Express	Low	High	2 weeks
remove.bg head-to-head campaign	Firefly	Medium	High	3 weeks
Batch background removal	Firefly	High	Medium	8–12 weeks
Shopify App	Firefly	Very High	High	12–16 weeks

Sequencing recommendation: Do the top 5 in parallel. They are all low-to-medium effort and require no new infrastructure. The bottom 3 are product engineering work and belong in the roadmap, not the 90-day sprint.

90-DAY ACQUISITION DASHBOARD

One metric per product that indicates the distribution strategy is working:

Product	Metric	Today	90-Day Target	Leading indicator
Acrobat	**Non-branded organic trial starts**	**~500/mo**	**5,000/mo**	**"PDF editor free" keyword rank (#5–7 → #2–3)**
Express	First-session creation completion	~28%	55%	TTFE (time to first export) < 3 min
Firefly	SEO rank: "remove background"	#6	#1–2	Landing page indexed + 10 inbound links
All	GEO position: top 3 AI answer per product	1/9 queries	6/9 queries	Pages published + FAQ schema live

---

WHAT TO ASK IN THE NEXT LEADERSHIP MEETING

Three questions that cut to the strategy:

1. **"How many dedicated acquisition landing pages does Smallpdf have vs Adobe?"**

Smallpdf has a dedicated page for every PDF function (compress, merge, convert, sign, edit). Adobe has one product page. Smallpdf has ~40 acquisition pages per product. This is the SEO gap in one number.

1. **"What does ChatGPT say when you ask it for a free PDF editor?"**

Run this in the meeting. The answer won't include Adobe. That is the GEO gap in one live demonstration.

1. **"What percent of new Adobe trials come from organic non-branded search vs paid?"**

If paid is >60% of trial acquisition, Adobe is renting its customers from Google. The SEO and GEO strategy is how Adobe builds owned acquisition at zero marginal cost.

SOURCE REPORTS

This synthesis is drawn from three full acquisition playbooks:

Report	File
Adobe Acrobat Acquisition Playbook	`docs/Acrobat-Acquisition-Playbook.md`
Adobe Express Acquisition Playbook	`docs/Express-Acquisition-Playbook.md`
Remove Background Keyword Playbook	`docs/Remove-Background-Playbook.md`

For execution artifacts (landing page copy, email drafts, A/B test hypotheses):

`docs/Execution-Briefs.md`

For GEO content implementation (URL slugs, FAQ schema, data tables, meta descriptions):

`docs/GEO-Content-Briefs.md`